

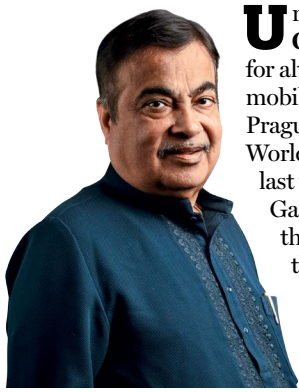
Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

ALL THE EX-PRESIDENT'S MEN

The appointment of Ajay Maken as Congress treasurer completes the placement of Rahul Gandhi favourites in key positions within the party's power circle. In fact, most of his close aides are better placed now when Mallikarjun Kharge is president than they were under Rahul Gandhi or Sonia Gandhi. Apart from Maken as treasurer and K.C. Venugopal as the general secretary in-charge of organisation, several others, including Jairam Ramesh, Randeep Singh Surjewala, Gaurav Gogoi, Jitendra Singh, Avinash Pande and Dipak Babaria, have been inducted into the Congress Working Committee (CWC), the highest decision-making body of the party. Ramesh handles communication while Surjewala, apart from being the in-charge of Congress-ruled Karnataka, has recently been given the same responsibility for poll-bound Madhya Pradesh. Among the permanent invitees to CWC are Manickam Tagore, Meenakshi Natarajan, K. Raju and Sachin Rao. Raju and Rao are part of the inner circle of Rahul Gandhi's office.

ONE FOR THE MISSUS

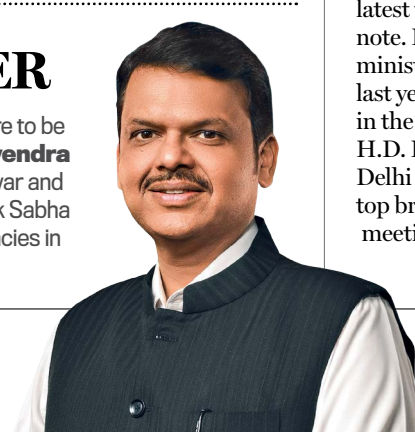


CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Union Minister **Nitin Gadkari's** fondness for alternative fuels for mobility is well known. In Prague to attend the 27th World Road Congress in the last week of September, Gadkari recounted before the Indian diaspora the story behind his own hydrogen car. Turns out that the Union minister's wife didn't believe him when he told her that cars could run on hydrogen derived from water. "She asked me who in the world would believe me when even she found it hard to believe that such a technology was possible and reliable," said Gadkari. That's when he decided to get a hydrogen-powered car for his daily use. "It's India's first hydrogen car. I even take the chief ministers who come to meet me for a spin in the car to inspire them about hydrogen fuel technology," he said. That's how you drive change.

BJP'S MAHA MAKEOVER

Is the Maharashtra BJP heading for a shake-up? If sources are to be believed, senior leaders, including deputy chief minister **Devendra Fadnavis** and ministers Girish Mahajan and Sudhir Mungantiwar and former minister Vinod Tawde, may be drafted to contest the Lok Sabha polls. All speculation has now shifted to who will fill these vacancies in the state once the first rung of leaders take up central roles.



BANDEEP SINGH

Kaushik Deka with Dhaval Kulkarni, Avishek G. Dastidar, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Ajay Sukumaran

LENS NAIKS



West Bengal governor **C.V. Ananda Bose** has alleged that he was "trapped and tracked" by the Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress government. Besides writing to the Union and state governments on the matter, he also quipped that outside the Raj Bhawan—his official residence—there is "violence, whereas inside it is "by lens". He has sought central security instead of personnel from the Bengal police to be instated inside Raj Bhawan, and requested a state-of-the-art security system, installation of jammers and debugging of the area. TMC leaders—smirking privately—say never has a governor made such demands, wondering if Bose was suffering from "fear psychosis". TMC leader Tapas Roy, reacting to Bose's claims, said the governor "must remember that constitutionally, the state government is his government".

CRACKS IN THE ALLIANCE



Rumblings in the Janata Dal (Secular) over its alliance with the BJP show no signs of abating, with the party's Karnataka president **C.M. Ibrahim** being the latest to strike a discordant note. Ibrahim, a former Union minister who joined the JD(S) last year, claims he wasn't kept in the loop when party leader H.D. Kumaraswamy visited Delhi recently to meet the BJP top brass. He has called for a meeting of supporters before spelling out his stance.